

Primary Source Reading 2: From Household to State

Optima Academy Online | Philosophy & Ethics | High School Honors (9–12) From Aristotle, Politics, Book I, translated by Benjamin Jowett Read before Lesson 17b: Political Communities and Their Purpose

Before you read: Aristotle opens the *Politics* with a claim about purpose, then traces how human communities grow from the smallest unit — the household — up through the village to the state. As you read, watch for the exact moment the purpose of the community changes: from mere survival to something more.

Every Community Aims at Some Good

Every state is a community of some kind, and every community is established with a view to some good; for mankind always act in order to obtain that which they think good. But, if all communities aim at some good, the state or political community, which is the highest of all, and which embraces all the rest, aims at good in a greater degree than any other, and at the highest good.

From Family to Village

Out of these two relationships between man and woman, master and slave, the first thing to arise is the family... The family is the association established by nature for the supply of men's everyday wants... But when several families are united, and the association aims at something more than the supply of daily needs, the first society to be formed is the village. And the most natural form of the village appears to be that of a colony from the family, composed of the children and grandchildren.

The State Comes Into Being for Living, but Exists for the Good Life

When several villages are united in a single complete community, large enough to be nearly or quite self-sufficing, the state comes into existence, originating in the bare needs of life, and continuing in existence for the sake of a good life. And therefore, if the earlier forms of society are natural, so is the state, for it is the end of them, and the nature of a thing is its end. For what each thing is when fully developed, we call its nature, whether we are speaking of a man, a horse, or a family. Besides, the final cause and end of a thing is the best, and to be self-sufficing is the end and the best.

Justice Is the Bond of Men in States

But justice is the bond of men in states, for the administration of justice, which is the determination of what is just, is the principle of order in political society.

After you read: Notice the phrase Aristotle uses for the state's origin: it comes into existence "originating in the bare needs of life, and continuing in existence for the sake of a good life." Both halves matter. The state begins from the same practical necessities that produced the household and the village — but what makes it a state, rather than just a bigger village, is that it becomes something more than a survival mechanism. As you read the lesson, keep this two-part formula in mind; it is the exact point where Aristotle's account of political life diverges from Hobbes's.